

Gathering Professional References

Estimated time needed: 3 minutes

Introduction

Most employers will ask you to provide references at some point in the interview process. They will, typically, check with the references before making you an offer. Therefore, it makes sense to collect references ahead of time.

Objectives

After completing this reading, you will be able to:

- Identify the information to collect from a reference
- Explain how to select professional references
- List examples of personal references

Reference details

Be sure to keep a directory of your references with their contact information somewhere you can easily find it. Starting early to collect references will also give you a chance to contact them to make sure that they are willing to talk to prospective employers on your behalf. Do not use references who have not given you permission. When you speak or write to them, you can also check each reference's current contact information and make sure you have their permission to share it.

Generally speaking, you will need some basic information from each reference.

Information Required	Example
• Name • Title • Company • Mailing address • Phone number • Email address	Sam Rogers Program Management Lead Maxwell Industries Inc. 1113 Watson Drive Seattle, WA 98101 (206) 777-2222 (Afternoons 1:00 – 5:00PM) SRogers@Maxwell.org

Professional references

Professional references refer to people who can comment on your past work history. Usually, they should be managers who worked with you and can discuss what you did at past jobs.

Note that some company policies might prohibit managers from discussing the details of your work, and they may only be able to verify that you worked at the company and your start and end dates. Check on this policy with them so that you know what you can expect them to share with prospective employers.

Most employers will prefer to talk to your supervisors as professional references, but you can also list:

- Colleagues, if they have worked closely with you
- Professors and coaches who are familiar with your classwork if you have a short work history
- People who have supervised or worked with you on a volunteer project

Make sure that whoever you add as a reference has had a positive work relationship with you and can provide positive feedback.

Personal references

Personal references are people who can talk about your personal character, trustworthiness, honesty, work ethic, and so on. You will rarely need these in modern interviews, but it doesn't hurt to gather some, just in case. They should be people who know you well but are not part of your family. Some examples might be:

- Friends
- Teachers
- Classmates
- Counsellors

Conclusion

When choosing references, be aware that they might reveal personal information about you that may not be appropriate, such as your religious affiliation if you choose clergy at your church or temple. As with professional references, gather their contact information and permission to be contacted.



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